MDES 401: Environment and Politics in the Middle East
Midterm Film Review

Political Ecology Review of *Al-Ard (The Land)*

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Al-Ard (*The Land*, 1970), directed by Youssef Chahine, is a powerful Egyptian drama set in a small Nile Delta village in the 1930s. The film follows a community of peasant farmers who depend on the land and shared irrigation for survival. Led by the steadfast elder Abu Suwaylam, the villagers face mounting injustices under Egypt's semi-colonial monarchy: first, a decree limiting their water access, and then a plan by the local lord (Mahmud Bey) to carve a road through their fields. As the peasants unite to petition authorities and later sabotage the road works, they encounter brutal retaliation from the landowning elite and colonial police. The story builds to a tragic climax in which Abu Suwaylam sacrifices himself defending the soil he cherishes. Through this narrative, *Al-Ard* portrays the villagers' bond with their land and the oppression they endure, setting the stage for a critique of social power and environmental injustice (Chahine, 1970).

Chahine's film can be seen as a critique of Neo-Malthusian ideas that blame resource scarcity on indigenous populations. In *Al-Ard*, water is scarce by design, not by nature. The authorities decree that villagers may irrigate their crops only a few days per month, a restriction that pits neighbor against neighbor and threatens their livelihoods. Rather than passively accept this "natural" fate, the peasants recognize the injustice and send a petition to Cairo, showing they understand the crisis is politically imposed, not an act of God or overpopulation. When the state ignores them, desperation leads the villagers to collectively break open the irrigation channels, illegally flooding their fields to save the crops. Dozens of men are arrested and harshly punished for this act of survival, a response out of proportion to the "crime". By illustrating how the struggle over water is provoked by exploitative policies and not by absolute water absence, *Al-Ard* aligns with political ecology's critique of neo-Malthusian narratives. As Verhoeven observes, simplistic "water wars" tropes often ignore how conflicts over resources are rooted in

social power and governance. Indeed, the film shows that scarcity violence is not inevitable – it is manufactured by those in power. This dramatization allows for the insight that blaming famine or water conflict on nature alone lets authorities evade responsibility for inequitable resource distribution (Verhoeven, 2019). In *Al-Ard*, the real villains are not drought or overpopulation, but the officials and landowners who manipulate water flows for control. By the end, the audience clearly sees that the resulting "water war" in the village is a man-made tragedy, challenging neo-Malthusian notions that the peasantry's suffering was simply the unavoidable outcome of scarce resources and indigenous ignorance.

The film's core conflict also explores oppressive rural class relations, laying bare the power imbalances between peasants, local elites, and colonial-era authorities. The village social hierarchy is stark; poor farmers toil in the fields, while the absentee landlord Mahmud Bey wields authority over land and water. Chahine depicts the Bey as decadent, Westernized, and utterly alienated from the land and people. In one telling scene, the Bey, dressed in European finery holding his bichon-type dog, rationalizes the seizure of peasant land for a new road by claiming it's for "development", and that cars will be able to drive directly to the front gate of his mansion by its completion (Chahine, 1970). His rhetoric echoes colonial condescension, implying that modern infrastructure is a benevolent gift to backward villagers, even as it destroys their fields. The Bey's stance is self-serving: he imposes himself on the land rather than living with it, and he prioritizes personal comfort over communal good. We see him cynically co-opting village notables – the schoolteacher (Muhammad Effendi) and religious men (Shaykh Hassuna, Shaykh Youssef) – by assuring them *their* own plots will be spared. In doing so, he isolates individual interests to weaken collective resistance, a tactic of a rural elite protecting its dominance. Meanwhile, the peasants who refuse to submit suffer violent repression.

The film does not shy away from depicting the cruelty of the old agrarian order; landlords who can murder peasant girls with impunity, police who torture innocents, and local chiefs who act as extensions of state authority (Downs, 1995). Such scenes emphasize the systematic nature of class oppression in the village. Yet, the peasants demonstrate solidarity and courage in the face of these abuses. Abu Suwaylam emerges as the moral center – a farmer of great dignity who rallies neighbors to defend their shared land rights. Their confrontations with the Bey, the Umda (village headman), and the colonial police reveal the broader social hierarchy; the *fellahin* (farmers) are at the bottom, yet they possess a righteous claim to the land through generations of labor. By highlighting the peasants' awareness of injustice and willingness to fight back, *Al-Ard* portrays rural class relations as an ongoing struggle rather than a static submission. The film mirrors a Marxian social critique; it depicts how an oppressed village, bound by brotherhood to the soil, challenges the "arbitrary injustice" of landlords and officials (Downs, 1995). The peasants' defeat symbolized by Abu Suwaylam losing his land to the Bey's road illustrates the harsh reality of class power, yet their resistance carries an implicit call for social change.

Al-Ard further engages with Orientalism by exposing Western-imposed narratives about Egyptian rural life. Orientalism, in this context, refers to the colonial-era mindset that justified domination by depicting the East as regressive, chaotic, or in need of Western "civilizing" interventions. In the film, this attitude surfaces in the behavior of the ruling class and colonial authorities. Mahmud Bey's condescending modernization talk – bringing "fresh water and electricity" to the village – encapsulates the colonial justification for dispossession; the peasants' land must be sacrificed for progress defined by outsiders. This mirrors what Verhoeven describes as the imperialist *"ecology of fear"* narrative, wherein European colonizers depict a degraded Oriental landscape to legitimize their rule and environmental engineering projects. The Bey's

view of the land solely as an exploitable resource rather than seeing people as part of the land's ecosystem (Downs, 1995) echoes the colonial gaze that treated native lands as empty sites for improvement. Chahine pointedly contrasts this with the villagers' own perspective. The film's narrative is told from the inside of the village, never through a foreign observer or "expert." Unlike earlier colonial literature where an outsider explains rural Egypt, here the peasants speak for themselves in their own dialect and cultural context. This storytelling choice refutes Orientalist practice by granting agency and voice to the fellahin rather than objectifying them. The villagers are not portrayed as exotic curiosities or passive victims; they are complex individuals with humor, desires, and a rich relationship to their environment.

Furthermore, the film dramatizes how colonial power infiltrates the village. The presence of the camel corps and a police commissioner enforcing the water quotas and road construction signifies the reach of imperial authority into everyday peasant life. We see local collaborators like the *'umda* and certain sheikhs acting as "satellites of established authority," parroting the occupiers' directives (Downs, 1995). For example, Shaykh al-Shinnawi in the film responds to crises only with calls to prayer, discouraging action – a subtle critique of how religion could be co-opted to pacify the oppressed. By showing villagers' skeptical attitude toward these figures of authority, *Al-Ard* dismantles the Orientalist illusion of a naive peasantry. Instead, Chahine exposes the colonial narrative as a self-serving lie; the promised "modernization" brings violence and dispossession, not enlightenment. The film's very existence as a piece of Egyptian cinema committed to social truth is itself an answer to Orientalism. By rooting its critique in local experience and national history, *Al-Ard* reclaims the narrative of the Egyptian fellah from colonial storytellers and affirms that the struggle for land and dignity is a story best told by those who live it.

Chahine reinforces these political themes through cinematographic choices that heighten the film's impact. Every stylistic element – from framing and lighting to sound design – works in tandem with the narrative to highlight *Al-Ard*'s messages about land, power, and resistance. The camera often frames Abu Suwaylam and the villagers in ways that highlight solidarity and their bond with the land. In group scenes, Abu Suwaylam is frequently centered as a pillar of strength – for instance, when villagers gather to discuss their grievances, he stands in the light at the frame's center, distinguished by a brighter garment amid the darker-clad crowd. This visual emphasis marks him as the moral focus and natural leader of the collective. Chahine's realism also involves the audience as if an eavesdropper; in some scenes, the camera observes an argument through a barred window or in near-complete darkness, partially obstructed, mimicking the viewpoint of a hidden observer. Such techniques bring a documentary-like authenticity, reinforcing that the political drama is a real village. Notably, the film's opening and closing shots create a powerful compositional bookend. It begins with a nurturing image of a peasant hand patting wet earth around a young plant (life emerging from land) and ends with the iconic sight of Abu Suwaylam's body being dragged across the dry, barren soil as he clutches onto the cotton stalks (life violently torn from the land) – a stark visual metaphor binding the hero's fate to the fate of the land itself. By framing the film between these two contrasting images, Chahine uses visual storytelling to reinforce that the loss of land is a loss of life and identity for the villagers.

Al-Ard (The Land) stands as a landmark film that masterfully critiques the injustices of environmental control, class oppression, and colonial ideology. Chahine uses the plight of one Egyptian village to refute neo-Malthusian determinism – showing that conflicts over water and land are not the natural outcome of scarcity, but the product of human greed and misrule. The peasants' struggle illustrates how resource scarcity is socially engineered, aligning with later

political ecologists' arguments that we must examine *who* wields power over resources rather than accept scarcity as destiny (Verhoeven, 2019). At the same time, the film provides a striking portrayal of rural class relations; the courage and camaraderie of the exploited versus the cruelty and corruption of the elites. By dramatizing how a landlord allied with colonial forces can devastate peasant lives, *Al-Ard* condemns the colonial structures that perpetuated rural misery in Egypt. Chahine's nuanced storytelling also dismantles Orientalist narratives. He empowers the Egyptian fellah as a speaking subject with wisdom and influence, while depicting the "civilizing" claims of the colonizer and his local agents as hollow and destructive. The film's rich cinematography reinforces every political point, searing into memory the notion that land is life for the rural poor. In the final frame, Abu Suwaylam's lifeless body entwined with the soil of his beloved farm is a haunting symbol of sacrifice that transcends the screen. It reminds viewers that the fight for environmental justice and dignity is as rooted and enduring as the land itself.

Over half a century later, *Al-Ard* remains profoundly significant – not only in Egyptian cinema or postcolonial studies, but in the discourse of political ecology. Chahine's film is an emotional call to recognize the human stakes in ecological struggles and a testament to the power of cinema to give voice to the dispossessed, asserting that true progress cannot be achieved until those who till the land are free from oppression.

Works cited:

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